Learn French for Beginners

Le Café des Questions

A story in 20 episodes · A1–B1

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The Café of Questions

A 20-episode story in a tiny Montmartre café whose owner serves you only after one question. In a tiny café on a steep street in Montmartre, Madame Rose, 70, has one rule, chalked on the slate by the door and signed O.: one question, then a coffee. Each customer walks in with a problem, and her simple question helps them see it differently, while Socrate, her grumpy grey parrot, gives his opinion without a word. Episode by episode, small clues show why she made the rule.

How to read

Each line gives the speaker and the French, then the English in italics. The respellings (English-style pronunciation, not IPA) are only in the word list at the end of each episode; ‿ marks a liaison there (*vous avez* = voo‿zah-vay). The questions for every episode and the answer key are at the end. The word in brackets after the English, such as *(teasing)*, says how the line is said.

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat
‿	liaison: the silent final consonant is pronounced at the start of the next word (*vous‿avez* = voo zah-vay)

The people

Thomas, customer in a hurry (episodes 1, 20)
Rose, café owner (episodes 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11, 13, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20)
Paul, groom-to-be (episodes 2, 17)
Hugo, Rose's great-nephew (episodes 3, 4, 9, 12, 14, 18, 19)
Emma, tourist (episode 4)
Antoine, customer (episode 5)
Léo, learner driver (episode 6)
Max, influencer (episode 7)
Bruno, office worker (episode 8)
Inès, nurse (episode 9)
Victor, amateur historian (episode 10)
Albert, old customer (episode 11)
Nadia, mother (episode 12)
Samuel, tired father (episode 13)
Juliette, postwoman (episode 14)
Karim, painter (episode 15)
Frédéric, rich customer (episode 16)

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Act 1 · Une question, puis un café (One question, then a coffee)

Level A1

Episode 1 · La règle (The rule)



On Monday at half past eight, Thomas rushes into a tiny café in Montmartre with a phone in each hand. Madame Rose puts a white cup on her side of the counter and taps the slate by the door, signed O. When a phone rings, Thomas answers it, and Socrate, the grey parrot by the window, turns his back on him. Later Thomas puts both phones down, and Rose slides the cup across.

Thomas Bonjour ! Un café, vite ! Je suis en retard.
Morning! A coffee, quick! I'm late. (worried)

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. Vite ? Ici, une question, puis un café.
Good morning. Quick? Here, it's one question, then a coffee. (teasing)

Thomas Une question ? Pour un café ? Je n'ai pas le temps !
A question? For a coffee? I haven't got time! (US: I don't have time) (annoyed)

Rose Socrate vous tourne le dos. Il n'est pas d'accord.
Socrate's turning his back on you. He doesn't approve. (amused)

Thomas Pardon. Et sur l'ardoise, c'est qui, O. ?
Sorry. And on the slate, who's O.? (curious)

Rose Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
Here, I'm the one who asks the questions. (teasing)

Rose Qu'est-ce que vous aimez, le matin ?
What do you like, in the morning? (curious)

Thomas Le matin ? Je cours. Je travaille. Avec mon café.
In the morning? I rush around. I work. Coffee in hand. (worried)

Thomas J'aime… le café. Et le silence.
I like… coffee. And silence. (surprised)

Thomas Merci. Je m'assois. Je reste cinq minutes.
Thanks. I'll sit down. I'll stay five minutes. (relieved)

Words from this episode

- **Je suis en retard** *(zhuh swee‿zahN ruh-tar)* — I'm late
- **un café** *(uhN kah-fay)* — a coffee (un: masculine)
- **Je n'ai pas le temps** *(zhuh nay pah luh tahN)* — I haven't got time (US: I don't have time)
- **pas d'accord** *(pah dah-kor)* — doesn't agree (d'accord: OK, agreed)
- **c'est moi qui pose les questions** *(seh mwah kee pohz lay kes-tyohN)* — I'm the one who asks the questions (poser une question: to ask a question)
- **Qu'est-ce que vous aimez** *(kes-kuh voo‿zeh-may)* — What do you like
- **Je cours** *(zhuh koor)* — I run, I rush around (courir)
- **Je travaille** *(zhuh trah-vahy)* — I work (je: -e; vous travaillez)
- **Je reste cinq minutes** *(zhuh rest saNk mee-newt)* — I'll stay five minutes (present for a decision now)

Notice: Present-tense endings: vous aimez, j'aime

Rose asks Qu'est-ce que vous aimez, le matin ? and Thomas answers J'aime… le café. The stem aim- stays the same; only the ending changes: -ez for vous, -e for je. Thomas's Je travaille works the same way: vous travaillez.

See the table: Grammar tables, Present-tense endings.

Sagesse du jour

« Chaque chose en son temps. » *(shahk shohz ahN sohN tahN)*

Literally: Each thing in its time.

Meaning: Give each thing its own moment: finish your coffee before the next task.

English equivalent: All in good time.

Episode 2 · Le discours (The speech)



On Thursday Paul sits at one of Madame Rose's three little tables with twelve pages and a pen: on Saturday he marries Léa. Rose drinks from her own blue cup with an O painted on it; customers get white ones. She puts Paul's white cup on her side of the counter. Later Socrate, the grey parrot, nibbles page twelve.

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. Un thé ? Vous êtes tout blanc.
Hello. A tea? You're as white as a sheet. (literally: all white) (curious)

Paul Samedi, je me marie. Écoutez : l'amour est une étoile…
I'm getting married on Saturday. Listen: 'Love is a star…' (worried)

Rose Douze pages ? Pour un mariage ?
Twelve pages? For a wedding? (amused)

Paul Je sais. J'écris, j'écris… et j'ai peur.
I know. I write and write… and I'm scared. (worried)

Rose Votre thé, après une question. La règle a quarante ans.
Your tea comes after one question. The rule is forty years old. (teasing)

Rose Pourquoi vous aimez Léa ?
Why do you love Léa? (curious)

Paul Parce qu'elle rit tout le temps. Parce qu'elle est gentille.
Because she laughs all the time. Because she's kind. (moved)

Paul Parce qu'avec elle, je suis moi.
Because with her, I'm me. (proud)

Rose Voilà votre discours. Et voilà votre thé.
There's your speech. And here's your tea. (proud)

Paul Ouf ! Et Socrate mange la page douze. Onze pages, alors !
Phew! And Socrate's eating page twelve. Eleven pages, then! (amused)

Rose Non, monsieur. Trois phrases. C'est tout.
No. Three sentences. That's all. (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **Vous êtes tout blanc** *(voo‿zet too blahN)* — You're as white as a sheet (être: vous êtes)
- **je me marie** *(zhuh muh mah-ree)* — I'm getting married (se marier: me for je)
- **Douze pages** *(dooz pahzh)* — twelve pages
- **J'écris** *(zhay-kree)* — I write
- **j'ai peur** *(zhay puhr)* — I'm scared (literally: I have fear)
- **La règle a quarante ans** *(lah reh-gluh ah kah-rahN-tahN)* — The rule is forty years old (avoir for age; no z after quarante)
- **Pourquoi vous aimez Léa** *(poor-kwah voo‿zeh-may lay-ah)* — Why do you love Léa
- **Parce qu'elle rit** *(pars kel ree)* — Because she laughs (qu' before a vowel)
- **votre discours** *(voh-truh dees-koor)* — your speech (polite)
- **C'est tout** *(seh too)* — That's all

Notice: Pourquoi… ? Parce que…

Rose asks Pourquoi vous aimez Léa ? and Paul answers three times with parce que. Before a vowel, que becomes qu': Parce qu'elle rit, Parce qu'avec elle. Pourquoi asks for a reason; parce que gives it.

See the table: Grammar tables, Question words.

Sagesse du jour

« Il ne faut pas chercher midi à quatorze heures. » *(eel nuh foh pah shair-shay mee-dee ah kah-tor-zuhr)*

Literally: You mustn't look for noon at two p.m.

Meaning: Don't make a simple thing complicated.

English equivalent: Keep it simple.

Episode 3 · Le petit-neveu (The great-nephew)



On Saturday at five past eight, Hugo, Rose's 22-year-old great-nephew, runs into the café for his first day at work, in an apron that is too short, and drops a white cup. Socrate, the grey parrot by the window, fluffs up, offended. Hugo sweeps up the pieces, and Rose puts a new white cup on her side of the counter and looks at him over her glasses.

Hugo J'arrive ! Pardon, Tata !
Coming! Sorry, Auntie! (worried)

Rose Pas de problème. Une tasse, deux euros.
No problem. One cup: two euros. (teasing)

Hugo Un café, s'il te plaît. Je suis de la famille !
A coffee, please. I'm family! (annoyed)

Rose La règle, c'est la règle. Même pour toi.
Rules are rules. Even for you. (teasing)

Rose Qu'est-ce que tu aimes faire, toi ?
And what do you like doing yourself? (curious)

Hugo J'aime faire des gâteaux. Mes parents aiment le droit.
I like baking cakes. My parents like law. (sad)

Hugo D'abord la tasse. Puis le café.
First the cup. Then the coffee. (proud)

Rose Voilà. Un café, puis un autre.
There you go. One coffee, then another. (amused)

Hugo Socrate a quel âge, Tata ?
How old is Socrate, Auntie? (curious)

Rose Cinquante ans ! Plus vieux que le Café des Questions.
Fifty! Older than the Café des Questions. (neutral)

Hugo Plus vieux que le café ? Le café a quel âge ?
Older than the café? How old is the café? (surprised)

Rose Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
Here, I'm the one who asks the questions. (teasing)

Words from this episode

- **J'arrive** *(zhah-reev)* — Coming! / I'm on my way
- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry
- **Pas de problème** *(pah duh proh-blem)* — No problem
- **s'il te plaît** *(seel tuh pleh)* — please (tu form; polite: s'il vous plaît)
- **Qu'est-ce que tu aimes faire** *(kes-kuh tew em fair)* — What do you like doing (to family)
- **J'aime faire des gâteaux** *(zhem fair day gah-toh)* — I like baking cakes (aimer + infinitive)
- **le droit** *(luh drwah)* — law (the subject; le: masculine)
- **Socrate a quel âge** *(soh-krat ah kel ahzh)* — How old is Socrate (avoir for age)
- **Cinquante ans** *(saN-kahN-tahN)* — fifty years old (no z after cinquante)

Notice: Tu or vous: family and customers

Hugo and Rose are family, so they say tu: Qu'est-ce que tu aimes faire, toi ?, s'il te plaît, Même pour toi. With customers Rose says vous, as in episodes 1 and 2: Qu'est-ce que vous aimez, le matin ? and Pourquoi vous aimez Léa ? So s'il te plaît becomes s'il vous plaît.

See the table: Grammar tables, Subject pronouns.

Sagesse du jour

« Petit à petit, l'oiseau fait son nid. » *(puh-tee‿tah puh-tee, lwah-zoh feh sohN nee)*

Literally: Little by little, the bird makes its nest.

Meaning: Patience and small steps get big things done.

English equivalent: Slowly but surely.

Episode 4 · Un jour à Paris (One day in Paris)



On Tuesday at ten, Madame Rose is at the market, so Hugo is alone behind the counter. Emma, an English tourist, comes in with a printed plan: Paris in one day, minute by minute. Hugo puts her white cup on his side, like Rose, and when Emma looks at her plan he points at the window; she crosses out half of it. Socrate steals a sugar cube from her saucer, and behind the counter hangs a row of postcards of the sea.

Emma Bonjour ! Un café, vite. J'ai un plan.
Hello! A coffee, quickly. I have a plan. (worried)

Hugo Ici, une question, puis un café. Votre couleur préférée ?
Here, it's one question, then a coffee. Your favourite colour? (US: favorite color) (teasing)

Emma Le bleu ? C'est la règle ?
Blue? Is that the rule? (amused)

Hugo Non… pardon. Ma vraie question : qu'est-ce que vous voyez, là ?
No… sorry. My real question: what can you see, right there? (curious)

Emma Mon plan ! À dix heures douze, une photo du Sacré-Cœur.
My plan! At 10:12, a photo of the Sacré-Cœur. (worried)

Emma Oh… Je vois les toits. Et le Sacré-Cœur. C'est beau.
Oh… I can see the roofs. And the Sacré-Cœur. It's beautiful. (moved)

Emma Et ces cartes postales de la mer, là ? C'est où ?
And those postcards of the sea, over there? Where is that? (curious)

Hugo À Saint-Malo. Tata Rose reçoit une carte chaque année.
In Saint-Malo. Auntie Rose gets a card every year. (neutral)

Emma De qui ?
Who from? (curious)

Hugo Je ne sais pas. Mystère !
I don't know. It's a mystery! (amused)

Emma Je reste. Un autre café, s'il vous plaît.
I'm staying. Another coffee, please. (relieved)

Words from this episode

- **J'ai un plan** *(zhay uhN plahN)* — I have a plan
- **Votre couleur préférée** *(voh-truh koo-luhr pray-fay-ray)* — your favourite colour (US: favorite color)
- **qu'est-ce que vous voyez** *(kes-kuh voo vwah-yay)* — what can you see (voir)
- **À dix heures douze** *(ah dee‿zuhr dooz)* — at 10:12 (à + the time)
- **du Sacré-Cœur** *(dew sah-kray-kuhr)* — of the Sacré-Cœur (de + le = du)
- **reçoit une carte** *(ruh-swah ewn kart)* — gets a card (recevoir)
- **chaque année** *(shahk ah-nay)* — every year
- **Je ne sais pas** *(zhuh nuh seh pah)* — I don't know
- **Je reste** *(zhuh rest)* — I'm staying
- **s'il vous plaît** *(seel voo pleh)* — please (polite)

Notice: Telling the time: à dix heures douze

Emma's plan uses à + the time: À dix heures douze, une photo du Sacré-Cœur. Say the hour, then heures, then the minutes: dix heures douze is 10:12. Noon is midi, with no heures.

See the table: Grammar tables, Telling the time.

Sagesse du jour

« Paris ne s'est pas fait en un jour. » *(pah-ree nuh seh pah feh ahN‿nuhN zhoor)*

Literally: Paris wasn't made in one day.

Meaning: Great things take time and patience; you can't do them all at once.

English equivalent: Rome wasn't built in a day.

Episode 5 · Monsieur Oui (Mister Yes)



On Friday morning Antoine comes into Madame Rose's café with his neighbour's dog on a lead, his boss's files and his sister's shopping. He says yes before anyone speaks, and he even says sorry to Socrate, the grey parrot by the window. Rose puts the white cup on her side of the counter and taps the slate.

Antoine Bonjour ! Oui, oui, d'accord !
Hello! Yes, yes, OK! (worried)

Rose Mais je ne demande rien, monsieur !
But I'm not asking anything! (teasing)

Antoine Ah… oui. Pardon. Pardon aussi, monsieur le perroquet !
Ah… right. Sorry. Sorry to you too, Mr Parrot! (worried)

Rose Vous dites pardon à Socrate ?
You're saying sorry to Socrate? (amused)

Antoine Je dis toujours oui. Mon chef, ma sœur, votre règle…
I always say yes. My boss, my sister, your rule… (sad)

Rose Ce n'est pas ma règle. Elle est à une amie.
It isn't my rule. It belongs to a friend. (neutral)

Rose Et vous, qu'est-ce que vous voulez ?
And you, what do you want? (curious)

Antoine Moi ? Je… Je ne veux pas garder le chien !
Me? I… I don't want to look after the dog! (surprised)

Antoine Et je n'aime pas les chiens.
And I don't like dogs. (relieved)

Rose Vous ne dites jamais non. Alors, c'est toujours oui.
You never say no. So it's always yes. (amused)

Rose Une part de tarte ? Cinq euros.
A slice of tart? Five euros. (teasing)

Antoine Non ! Non, merci. Mon premier non !
No! No, thank you. My first no! (proud)

Words from this episode

- **D'accord** *(dah-kor)* — OK, all right
- **Je ne demande rien** *(zhuh nuh duh-mahNd ryaN)* — I'm not asking anything (ne… rien: nothing)
- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry
- **Je dis toujours oui** *(zhuh dee too-zhoor wee)* — I always say yes (dire: je dis)
- **ma règle** *(mah reh-gluh)* — my rule (ma: feminine)
- **Et vous** *(ay voo)* — And you? (vous after et: stressed form)
- **qu'est-ce que vous voulez** *(kes-kuh voo voo-lay)* — what do you want
- **Je ne veux pas** *(zhuh nuh vuh pah)* — I don't want (ne + verb + pas)
- **Je n'aime pas les chiens** *(zhuh nem pah lay shyaN)* — I don't like dogs (n' before a vowel)
- **Cinq euros** *(saN-kuh-roh)* — five euros (no z after cinq)

Notice: Saying no: ne… pas

Antoine finally says Je ne veux pas garder le chien ! and Je n'aime pas les chiens. Ne goes before the verb and pas after it; before a vowel, ne becomes n'. Rose's Vous ne dites jamais non works the same way, with jamais (never) instead of pas.

See the table: Grammar tables, Negative words.

Sagesse du jour

« Qui ne dit mot consent. » *(kee nuh dee moh kohN-sahN)*

Literally: Who says no word consents.

Meaning: If you say nothing, people think you agree.

English equivalent: Silence gives consent.

Act 2 · Ce qui s'est passé (What happened)

Level A2

Episode 6 · Le permis (The driving test)



On a Thursday morning Léo, seventeen, drops into a chair in Rose's tiny Montmartre café: he has just failed his driving test. Rose puts a white cup on her side of the counter and points at the slate by the door. When Léo tells the truth, Socrate the grey parrot fluffs up his feathers.

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. Vous voulez un chocolat chaud ?
Hello, sir. Would you like a hot chocolate? (neutral)

Léo Vous ? Moi ? Personne ne me dit vous !
'Vous'? To me? Nobody says 'vous' to me! (surprised)

Rose Ici, je dis vous à tout le monde. Même à Socrate.
Here I say 'vous' to everyone. Even to Socrate. (teasing)

Léo J'ai raté mon permis ce matin. Je suis nul.
I failed my driving test this morning. I'm useless. (US: driver's test) (sad)

Rose Nul ? Vous avez dix-sept ans, monsieur.
Useless? You're seventeen, sir. (amused)

Léo Je suis parti trop vite. L'examinateur a crié. J'en ai marre !
I pulled away too fast. The examiner shouted. I'm fed up! (annoyed)

Rose Alors, ma question. Qu'est-ce que vous avez appris ce matin ?
So, my question. What did you learn this morning? (curious)

Léo J'ai appris… à regarder à droite. Et à partir doucement.
I learnt… to look to the right. And to pull away gently. (US: learned) (relieved)

Rose Moi aussi, j'ai raté un examen. Ce n'est pas grave.
I failed an exam once too. It doesn't matter. (neutral)

Léo Je vais repasser le permis en juin. Et vous, alors ?
I'm going to retake the test in June. And what about you, then? (hopeful)

Rose Alors ? Je suis là. Et je suis contente.
Then? I'm here. And I'm happy. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **J'ai raté mon permis** *(zhay rah-tay mohN pair-mee)* — I failed my driving test (rater: avoir in the passé composé)
- **dix-sept ans** *(dee-se-tahN)* — seventeen (years old) (avoir dix-sept ans; no z after sept)
- **Je suis parti** *(zhuh swee par-tee)* — I left / I pulled away (partir takes être)
- **J'en ai marre !** *(zhahN‿nay mar)* — I'm fed up! (informal)
- **Qu'est-ce que vous avez appris** *(kes-kuh voo‿zah-vay ah-pree)* — What did you learn (apprendre → appris)
- **regarder à droite** *(ruh-gar-day ah drwaht)* — to look to the right
- **partir doucement** *(par-teer doos-mahN)* — to pull away gently
- **Ce n'est pas grave** *(suh neh pah grahv)* — It doesn't matter (spoken: c'est pas grave)
- **Je vais repasser le permis** *(zhuh veh ruh-pah-say luh pair-mee)* — I'm going to retake the test (aller + infinitive)

Notice: Être or avoir: je suis parti, j'ai raté

Léo says J'ai raté mon permis and J'ai appris à regarder, but Je suis parti trop vite. Most verbs make the passé composé with avoir; partir is one of the être verbs (aller, arriver, partir, rester, tomber…). With être the participle agrees: Rose would say je suis partie.

See the table: Grammar tables, Verbs that take être in the passé composé.

Sagesse du jour

« C'est en forgeant qu'on devient forgeron. » *(seh‿tahN for-zhahN kohN duh-vyaN for-zhuh-rohN)*

Literally: It's by forging that you become a blacksmith.

Meaning: You learn by doing it again and again, mistakes included.

English equivalent: Practice makes perfect.

Episode 7 · L'influenceur (The influencer)



On a Saturday afternoon Max, an influencer, walks into Rose's tiny Montmartre café filming himself. Rose waits behind the counter while Hugo works in the small kitchen. When Max holds up his phone for a selfie with Socrate, the grey parrot turns his back. Rose keeps the white cup on her side until Max answers.

Max Salut tout le monde ! Je suis au café secret. C'est génial !
Hi everyone! I'm at the secret café. It's brilliant! (proud)

Rose Ici, on dit bonjour à la dame.
Here, we say hello to the lady. (teasing)

Max Pardon ! Bonjour, madame. J'ai deux cent mille abonnés !
Sorry! Hello, madam. I've got two hundred thousand followers! (amused)

Rose Moi, j'ai un perroquet. Il ne m'aime pas non plus.
I've got a parrot. He doesn't like me either. (teasing)

Max Un selfie avec lui ? Oh ! Il m'a tourné le dos !
A selfie with him? Oh! He's turned his back on me! (surprised)

Rose Socrate a connu la première patronne. Il n'aime pas les photos.
Socrate knew the first owner. He doesn't like photos. (amused)

Max Bon, bon. Et la question, je la filme ?
All right, all right. And the question, shall I film it? (annoyed)

Rose Non, vous la vivez. Qu'avez-vous vu aujourd'hui ? Pas filmé : vu.
No, you live it. What have you seen today? Not filmed: seen. (curious)

Max J'ai vu… mon téléphone. Je n'ai pas regardé Paris.
I saw… my phone. I didn't look at Paris. (sad)

Rose Votre café, monsieur. Paris est là, derrière la fenêtre.
Your coffee, sir. Paris is right there, behind the window. (neutral)

Max Je vais rester un peu. Sans vidéo.
I'm going to stay a while. No video. (relieved)

Words from this episode

- **C'est génial !** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — It's brilliant! (US: awesome)
- **on dit bonjour** *(ohN dee bohN-zhoor)* — we say hello (on = people in general)
- **deux cent mille abonnés** *(duh sahN meel ah-bu-nay)* — two hundred thousand followers (cent, mille: no -s here)
- **Il ne m'aime pas non plus** *(eel nuh mem pah nohN plew)* — He doesn't like me either
- **Il m'a tourné le dos** *(eel mah toor-nay luh doh)* — He's turned his back on me
- **Socrate a connu** *(soh-krat ah koh-new)* — Socrate knew (connaître → connu)
- **Qu'avez-vous vu** *(kah-vay voo vew)* — What have you seen? (voir → vu)
- **Je n'ai pas regardé Paris** *(zhuh nay pah ruh-gar-day pah-ree)* — I didn't look at Paris (ne… pas around ai)
- **Je vais rester un peu** *(zhuh veh res-tay uhN puh)* — I'm going to stay a while (aller + infinitive)

Notice: Ne… pas in the past: je n'ai pas regardé

Max says Je n'ai pas regardé Paris. In the passé composé, ne… pas goes around the auxiliary (n'ai pas), and the past participle comes after it. Rien works the same way (je n'ai rien vu), while in the present ne… pas goes around the verb itself: Il n'aime pas les photos.

See the table: Grammar tables, Where the negative goes.

Sagesse du jour

« Tout ce qui brille n'est pas or. » *(too suh kee breey neh pah or)*

Literally: All that shines is not gold.

Meaning: Things that look wonderful aren't always what they seem.

English equivalent: All that glitters is not gold.

Episode 8 · Le vélo (The bicycle)



On a Monday morning Bruno, in a grey suit, stares into his white cup at the counter of Rose's Montmartre café before it is even full. There is a little black bike grease on his hands. Rose keeps the cup on her side until he answers, and Socrate the parrot steals Bruno's sugar cube.

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. Vous avez l'air triste.
Hello, sir. You look sad. (neutral)

Bruno C'est lundi.
It's Monday. (sad)

Rose C'est lundi ? Ah. Ça explique tout.
It's Monday? Ah. That explains everything. (teasing)

Bruno Je travaille dans les assurances depuis vingt-cinq ans. J'en ai assez.
I've worked in insurance for twenty-five years. I've had enough. (annoyed)

Rose Quand est-ce que vous avez été heureux, la semaine dernière ?
When were you happy, last week? (curious)

Bruno Samedi, j'ai réparé le vélo de mon voisin. Quatre heures !
On Saturday I repaired my neighbour's bike. Four hours! (US: neighbor's) (surprised)

Bruno C'est bête, quand même. Un vélo… Mais j'ai été heureux.
It's silly, though. A bike… But I was happy. (moved)

Rose Pas bête. Moi aussi, j'ai changé de vie. Il y a longtemps.
Not silly. I changed my life too. A long time ago. (neutral)

Bruno Ah bon ? Pourquoi ?
Really? Why? (curious)

Rose Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
Here, I'm the one who asks the questions. (teasing)

Bruno Du coup, je vais passer au magasin de vélos, rue Lepic.
So I'm going to drop by the bike shop on rue Lepic. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Je travaille** *(zhuh trah-vahy)* — I work (travailler)
- **depuis vingt-cinq ans** *(duh-pwee vaNt-saN-kahN)* — for twenty-five years (and still now: depuis + present)
- **vous avez été** *(voo‿zah-vay ay-tay)* — you were / you have been (être → été)
- **la semaine dernière** *(lah suh-men dair-nyair)* — last week (like l'année dernière)
- **quand même** *(kahN mem)* — though / all the same
- **j'ai changé de vie** *(zhay shahN-zhay duh vee)* — I changed my life (changer de + noun, no article)
- **Du coup** *(dew koo)* — So / as a result (spoken)
- **je vais passer** *(zhuh veh pah-say)* — I'm going to drop by (aller + infinitive)

Notice: Time words: depuis, il y a, la semaine dernière

Bruno says Je travaille dans les assurances depuis vingt-cinq ans: depuis + the present means it started then and is still going on. Rose says J'ai changé de vie. Il y a longtemps: il y a + a time means ago, with the passé composé. La semaine dernière (last week) is built like the table's l'année dernière.

See the table: Grammar tables, Common time expressions.

Sagesse du jour

« Il n'y a pas de sot métier. » *(eel nyah pah duh soh may-tyay)*

Literally: There's no stupid job.

Meaning: Every honest job deserves respect; none is beneath anyone.

English equivalent: There's no shame in honest work.

Episode 9 · L'appel (The phone call)



On a Tuesday morning Rose is at the market, so Hugo runs the counter of the Montmartre café, wearing his great-aunt's reading glasses to look serious; they keep slipping down his nose. Inès, a nurse still in her tunic after a night shift, puts her phone on the table, picks it up and puts it down again. When she says ma mère, Socrate the parrot fluffs up his feathers, and Hugo glances at the slate signed O. Later Inès steps outside with her phone and comes back with red eyes and a smile.

Hugo Bonjour, madame. Ici, une question, puis un café.
Hello, madam. Here: one question, then a coffee. (proud)

Inès Je suis fatiguée. J'ai travaillé toute la nuit.
I'm tired. I worked all night. (sad)

Hugo Oups. Les lunettes de Tata Rose. C'est pour avoir l'air sérieux.
Oops. Auntie Rose's glasses. They're to make me look serious. (surprised)

Inès Vous êtes drôle. D'accord, je vous écoute.
You're funny. All right, I'm listening. (amused)

Hugo Vous attendez un appel de qui ?
Whose call are you waiting for? (curious)

Inès De ma mère. On s'est disputées il y a trois mois.
My mother's. We had a row three months ago. (US: a fight) (sad)

Hugo Et vous, vous l'avez appelée ? Dimanche, c'est la fête des Mères.
And you, have you called her? Sunday is Mother's Day. (hopeful)

Inès Non. Elle ne m'a pas appelée non plus. J'attends.
No. She hasn't called me either. I'm waiting. (annoyed)

Hugo La règle vient d'une dame, Odette. Tata Rose ne parle jamais d'elle.
The rule comes from a lady, Odette. Auntie Rose never talks about her. (neutral)

Inès Je vais l'appeler tout de suite. Et je vais lui dire pardon.
I'm going to call her right now. And I'm going to say sorry to her. (hopeful)

Inès Elle a pleuré. Moi aussi. Et maintenant, mon café, s'il vous plaît !
She cried. So did I. And now, my coffee, please! (relieved)

Words from this episode

- **Je suis fatiguée** *(zhuh swee fah-tee-gay)* — I'm tired (fatiguée: a woman speaking)
- **J'ai travaillé toute la nuit** *(zhay trah-vah-yay toot lah nwee)* — I worked all night
- **Vous attendez un appel** *(voo‿zah-tahN-day uhN‿nah-pel)* — You're waiting for a call (attendre: no word for 'for')
- **il y a trois mois** *(eel ee ah trwah mwah)* — three months ago (il y a = ago)
- **vous l'avez appelée** *(voo lah-vay ah-puh-lay)* — have you called her? (l' = her, so appelée agrees)
- **Je vais l'appeler** *(zhuh veh lah-puh-lay)* — I'm going to call her (l' before the infinitive)
- **tout de suite** *(too duh sweet)* — right now / straight away
- **je vais lui dire pardon** *(zhuh veh lwee deer par-dohN)* — I'm going to say sorry to her (lui = to her)
- **Elle a pleuré** *(el ah pluh-ray)* — She cried (pleurer)

Notice: L' or lui? Je vais l'appeler, je vais lui dire

Inès says Je vais l'appeler and Je vais lui dire pardon. Appeler takes a direct object (appeler sa mère → l'appeler), but dire takes à (dire pardon à sa mère → lui dire pardon). In the passé composé, a direct object before avoir makes the participle agree: vous l'avez appelée, elle ne m'a pas appelée.

See the table: Grammar tables, Indirect object pronouns: me, lui, leur...

Sagesse du jour

« Mieux vaut tard que jamais. » *(myuh voh tar kuh zhah-meh)*

Literally: Late is worth more than never.

Meaning: It's better to do something late than not at all.

English equivalent: Better late than never.

Episode 10 · La vieille photo (The old photo)



On a Wednesday Victor, an amateur historian with a notebook, walks into Rose's Montmartre café already asking questions. Rose puts the white cup on her side of the counter and counts his questions on her fingers, and after the fifth one Socrate the parrot turns his back. In his bag Victor has a photo from 1975 that he bought at a flea market on Sunday: a woman in a big hat in front of this door. Above the door, the old name is still faint under the new sign.

Victor Bonjour ! Le café a quel âge ? Le comptoir est d'origine ?
Hello! How old is the café? Is the counter original? (curious)

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. Ça fait deux questions.
Hello, sir. That's two questions. (teasing)

Victor Et le perroquet ? Il parle ? Vous êtes là depuis quand ?
And the parrot? Does he talk? How long have you been here? (curious)

Rose Cinq. Regardez, Socrate vous tourne le dos.
Five. Look, Socrate is turning his back on you. (amused)

Victor Pardon ! J'écris un blog sur le vieux Montmartre.
Sorry! I write a blog about old Montmartre. (proud)

Rose Une question. Une. C'est moi qui la pose.
One question. One. And I'm the one who asks it. (annoyed)

Rose Qu'est-ce que votre femme vous a dit ce matin ?
What did your wife say to you this morning? (curious)

Victor Ma femme ? Je ne sais pas. Je n'ai pas écouté.
My wife? I don't know. I didn't listen. (surprised)

Rose Votre café, monsieur. Vous l'avez mérité.
Your coffee, sir. You've earned it. (teasing)

Victor Merci. Regardez ! Sur la photo, le café s'appelle Chez Odette.
Thank you. Look! In the photo, the café is called Chez Odette. (curious)

Rose Odette… Vous avez trouvé Odette.
Odette… You've found Odette. (moved)

Victor Ce soir, je vais écouter ma femme. Une heure. Sans carnet.
Tonight I'm going to listen to my wife. For an hour. No notebook. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Le café a quel âge** *(luh kah-fay ah kel ahzh)* — How old is the café? (avoir + age)
- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry / excuse me
- **J'écris un blog** *(zhay-kree uhN blog)* — I write a blog (écrire)
- **votre femme vous a dit** *(voh-truh fahm voo‿zah dee)* — your wife said to you (dire → dit)
- **Je n'ai pas écouté** *(zhuh nay pah ay-koo-tay)* — I didn't listen (écouter)
- **Vous l'avez mérité** *(voo lah-vay may-ree-tay)* — You've earned it (l' = the coffee)
- **Vous avez trouvé Odette** *(voo‿zah-vay troo-vay oh-det)* — You've found Odette (trouver)
- **Ce soir** *(suh swahr)* — This evening / tonight (ce = this)
- **je vais écouter** *(zhuh veh ay-koo-tay)* — I'm going to listen (aller + infinitive)

Notice: The near future: je vais écouter

Victor ends with Ce soir, je vais écouter ma femme: the present of aller (je vais, vous allez, elle va) + an infinitive says what is going to happen. In speech it is much more common than the futur simple in the table (j'écouterai). Inès did the same last time: Je vais l'appeler.

See the table: Grammar tables, Futur simple: endings and irregular stems.

Sagesse du jour

« Il n'est pire sourd que celui qui ne veut pas entendre. » *(eel neh peer soor kuh suh-lwee kee nuh vuh pah ahN-tahN-druh)*

Literally: There's no worse deaf man than the one who doesn't want to hear.

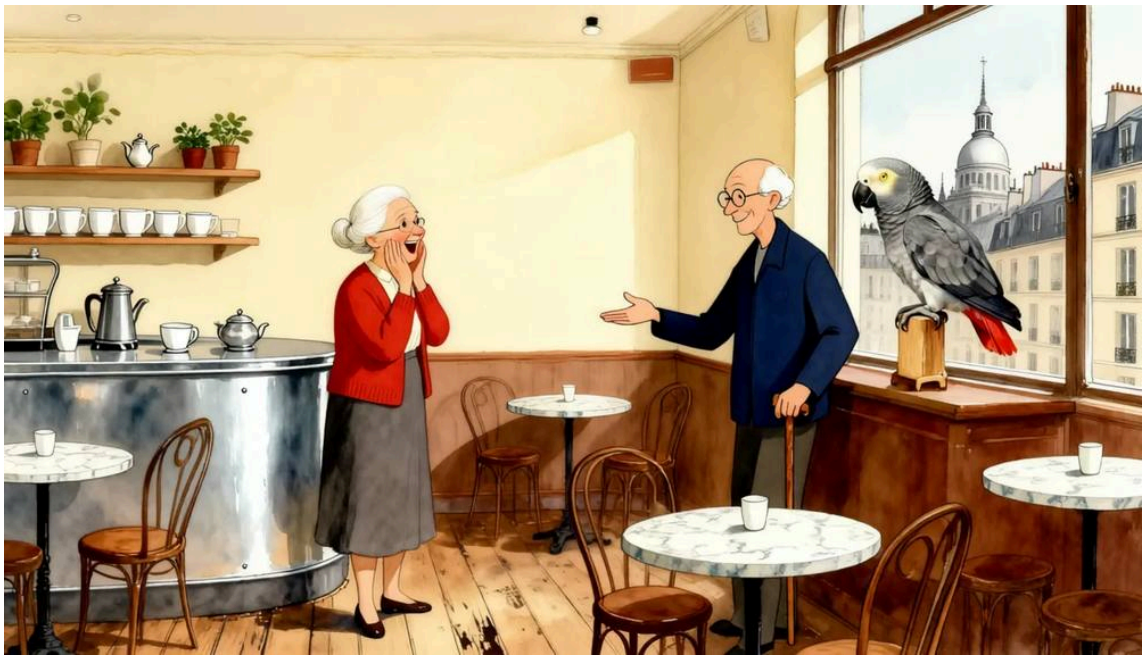
Meaning: The hardest person to reach is the one who won't listen.

English equivalent: There are none so deaf as those who will not hear.

Act 3 · Les souvenirs (Memories (A2+))

Level A2

Episode 11 · Le bal du samedi (Saturday dances)



On a Monday morning in June, an old man with a cane stops at the door of the tiny Montmartre café and stares at the slate. Albert, 82, used to deliver the post on this street, and he recognises Madame Rose before she recognises him. He orders a white coffee; Rose puts the white cup on her side of the counter and taps the slate. On his perch, Socrate fluffs up his feathers for Albert.

Albert Mademoiselle Rose ? La petite étudiante ? Moi, c'est Albert, le facteur !
Miss Rose? The little student? It's me, Albert, the postman! (US: mailman) (surprised)

Rose Albert ! Le facteur ! Ça fait presque cinquante ans !
Albert! The postman! It's been almost fifty years! (moved)

Albert Vous étiez toujours pressée. Vous buviez votre café debout.
You were always in a hurry. You drank your coffee standing up. (amused)

Albert Un matin, Odette vous a posé une question. C'était quoi ?
One morning, Odette asked you a question. What was it? (curious)

Rose Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
Here, I'm the one who asks the questions. (teasing)

Rose Qu'est-ce que vous aimiez faire le samedi soir ?
What did you like to do on Saturday nights? (curious)

Albert Je dansais ! Au bal, place des Abbesses. Je dansais très bien.
I used to dance! At the dance, on the place des Abbesses. I danced very well. (proud)

Albert Mais maintenant, j'ai quatre-vingt-deux ans. Je suis trop vieux.
But now I'm eighty-two. I'm too old. (sad)

Rose Vous devriez danser encore. Il y a un bal samedi, à la mairie.
You should dance again. There's a dance on Saturday, at the town hall. (hopeful)

Albert D'accord ! Mais vous venez avec moi, mademoiselle Rose ?
All right! But will you come with me, Miss Rose? (hopeful)

Rose Moi ? Oh non, je suis trop vieille !
Me? Oh no, I'm too old! (surprised)

Albert Ah non ! Pas vous aussi !
Oh no! Not you too! (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Vous étiez toujours pressée** *(voo‿zay-tyay too-zhoor preh-say)* — You were always in a hurry (étiez: imparfait of être)
- **Vous buviez votre café debout** *(voo bew-vyay voh-truh kah-fay duh-boo)* — You used to drink your coffee standing up (boire: nous buvons → vous buviez)
- **Ça fait presque cinquante ans** *(sah feh presk saN-kahN-tahN)* — It's been almost fifty years (cinquante ans: no z)
- **c'est moi qui pose les questions** *(seh mwah kee pohz lay kes-tyohN)* — I'm the one who asks the questions
- **Qu'est-ce que vous aimiez faire** *(kes-kuh voo‿zeh-myay fair)* — What did you like to do (aimiez: imparfait)
- **j'ai quatre-vingt-deux ans** *(zhay kah-truh-vaN-duh‿zahN)* — I'm eighty-two (avoir for age)
- **Vous devriez danser** *(voo duh-vree-yay dahN-say)* — You should dance (vous devriez + infinitive: advice)
- **D'accord** *(dah-kor)* — All right / OK
- **je suis trop vieille** *(zhuh swee troh vyey)* — I'm too old (vieux → vieille for a woman)

Notice: The imparfait: vous étiez, je dansais

Albert remembers: Vous étiez toujours pressée. Vous buviez votre café debout. Je dansais très bien. Habits and descriptions in the past take the imparfait: the nous stem (nous buvons → buv-) plus -ais, -ait, -iez, with être as the one irregular stem (ét-). For one single event Albert uses the passé composé: Un matin, Odette vous a posé une question.

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Sagesse du jour

« C'est dans les vieux pots qu'on fait les meilleures soupes. » *(seh dahN lay vyuh poh kohN feh lay meh-yuhr soop)*

Literally: It's in the old pots that you make the best soups.

Meaning: Experience and age are an advantage, not a weakness.

English equivalent: There's many a good tune played on an old fiddle.

Episode 12 · Le gâteau brûlé (The burnt cake)



On Tuesday morning, while Rose is at the market, Hugo runs the tiny Montmartre café alone. Nadia, a pharmacist, puts a black, burnt three-tier cake on the counter. On his perch, Socrate turns his back on the cake, and Hugo puts the white cup on his side of the counter, just like his great-aunt. At the end, Nadia ties on an apron and Socrate helps himself to the apples.

Nadia Bonjour. Voilà mon gâteau. Enfin… c'était mon gâteau.
Hello. Here's my cake. Well… it was my cake. (annoyed)

Hugo Oh là là ! Même Socrate ne veut pas le regarder !
Oh dear! Even Socrate won't look at it! (amused)

Nadia C'est pour ma fille, Lina. Elle va avoir huit ans samedi.
It's for my daughter, Lina. She's going to be eight on Saturday. (sad)

Nadia Le gâteau du magazine… Trois étages, des décorations en or. Brûlé deux fois !
The cake from the magazine… Three tiers, gold decorations. Burnt twice! (annoyed)

Hugo Bon. Ici, une question, puis un café. Même pour un gâteau brûlé.
Right. Here: one question, then a coffee. Even for a burnt cake. (teasing)

Hugo Quand Lina était petite, qu'est-ce qu'elle aimait manger ?
When Lina was little, what did she like to eat? (curious)

Nadia Elle adorait la tarte aux pommes de sa grand-mère.
She loved her grandmother's apple tart. (moved)

Nadia Simple. Avec du beurre et du sucre.
Simple. With butter and sugar. (surprised)

Hugo Il faut faire simple. Vous devriez faire une tarte aux pommes.
You have to keep it simple. You should make an apple tart. (hopeful)

Nadia Une tarte ? Mais je ne sais pas faire les tartes !
A tart? But I don't know how to make tarts! (worried)

Hugo Tata Rose fait la tarte d'Odette depuis quarante ans. Elle m'a appris la recette.
Auntie Rose has been making Odette's tart for forty years. She taught me the recipe. (proud)

Hugo Ce n'est pas la mer à boire. Je vous montre ?
It's not that hard. Shall I show you? (literally: it's not the sea to drink) (hopeful)

Nadia D'accord ! Mais regardez Socrate : il mange déjà les pommes !
All right! But look at Socrate: he's already eating the apples! (amused)

Words from this episode

- **c'était mon gâteau** *(say-teh mohN gah-toh)* — it was my cake (c'était: imparfait of c'est)
- **Enfin** *(ahN-faN)* — Well… / I mean (correcting yourself)
- **huit ans** *(wee‿tahN)* — eight years old (huit + ans: t liaison)
- **qu'est-ce qu'elle aimait manger** *(kes-kel eh-meh mahN-zhay)* — what did she like to eat (aimait: imparfait)
- **du beurre et du sucre** *(dew buhr ay dew sew-kruh)* — butter and sugar (du: some, partitive)
- **Il faut faire simple** *(eel foh fair saN-pluh)* — You have to keep it simple (il faut + infinitive)
- **Vous devriez faire une tarte aux pommes** *(voo duh-vree-yay fair ewn tart oh pum)* — You should make an apple tart (advice)
- **Elle m'a appris la recette** *(el mah ah-pree lah ruh-set)* — She taught me the recipe (apprendre quelque chose à quelqu'un)
- **Ce n'est pas la mer à boire** *(suh neh pah lah mair ah bwahr)* — It's not that hard
- **Je vous montre ?** *(zhuh voo mohN-truh)* — Shall I show you?

Notice: Giving advice: il faut, vous devriez

Hugo gives advice two ways: Il faut faire simple and Vous devriez faire une tarte aux pommes. Il faut + infinitive states a general rule (you have to), while vous devriez + infinitive, devoir in the conditional, is a softer, personal suggestion (you should). To a friend it's tu devrais: Tu devrais essayer.

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Sagesse du jour

« Le mieux est l'ennemi du bien. » *(luh myuh eh len-mee dew byaN)*

Literally: The best is the enemy of the good.

Meaning: Trying to make something perfect can spoil what was already good.

English equivalent: Perfect is the enemy of good.

Episode 13 · Pourquoi, pourquoi, pourquoi (Why, why, why)



On Friday at eight, Samuel collapses at one of the three little tables of the Montmartre café. Every morning he walks past the window with his son Noé, six, who asks 'why' from seven o'clock. Rose puts the white cup on her side of the counter and looks at him over her glasses. Socrate, silent as always, watches from his perch by the window.

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. Vous avez l'air fatigué.
Good morning. You look tired. (teasing)

Samuel Un café. Double. Ne me posez pas de question.
A coffee. A double. Don't ask me any questions. (annoyed)

Rose Ah, ça, c'est impossible. Ici, une question, puis un café.
Ah, that's impossible. Here: one question, then a coffee. (amused)

Samuel Mon fils a six ans. Ce matin : « Pourquoi le perroquet ne dit rien ? »
My son is six. This morning: 'Why doesn't the parrot say anything?' (annoyed)

Rose Il réfléchit. Socrate réfléchit depuis cinquante ans.
He's thinking. Socrate has been thinking for fifty years. (amused)

Rose Et vous, quand vous étiez petit, vous posiez des questions ?
And you, when you were little, did you ask questions? (curious)

Samuel Oui… tout le temps. Et mon père disait : « Parce que. »
Yes… all the time. And my father used to say: 'Because.' (sad)

Samuel Je n'aimais pas ça… Et moi, je dis la même chose !
I didn't like that… And I say the same thing! (surprised)

Rose Quand j'étais jeune, je ne posais pas de questions. Je courais.
When I was young, I didn't ask questions. I ran. (moved)

Samuel Alors, qu'est-ce que je dois faire ?
So what should I do? (curious)

Rose Vous devriez lui poser une question, à lui.
You should be the one asking him a question. (neutral)

Rose « Et toi, pourquoi tu penses que le ciel est bleu ? »
'And you, why do you think the sky is blue?' (teasing)

Samuel Alors, moi, je vais lui demander : « Et toi ? »
So I'm going to ask him: 'And you?' (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **fatigué** *(fah-tee-gay)* — tired (Vous avez l'air fatigué: you look tired)
- **Ne me posez pas de question** *(nuh muh poh-zay pah duh kes-tyohN)* — Don't ask me any questions
- **vous posiez des questions** *(voo poh-zyay day kes-tyohN)* — you used to ask questions (posiez: imparfait)
- **mon père disait** *(mohN pair dee-zeh)* — my father used to say (dire: imparfait)
- **Et moi** *(ay mwah)* — And me / And I (moi: stressed pronoun)
- **qu'est-ce que je dois faire** *(kes-kuh zhuh dwah fair)* — what should I do (devoir: must, should)
- **Vous devriez lui poser une question** *(voo duh-vree-yay lwee poh-zay ewn kes-tyohN)* — You should ask him a question (advice)
- **tu penses que** *(tew pahNs kuh)* — you think that (tu: to a child)

Notice: Stressed pronouns: moi, toi, lui, vous

Rose asks Et vous, quand vous étiez petit… ? and Samuel answers Et moi, je dis la même chose ! After et, on their own, or to stress a person, French uses moi, toi, lui, vous instead of je, tu, il: Alors, moi…, une question, à lui. Et toi ? is tu because it's what Samuel will say to his six-year-old son; Rose and Samuel still say vous to each other.

See the table: Grammar tables, Stressed pronouns: moi, toi...

Sagesse du jour

« La vérité sort de la bouche des enfants. » *(lah vay-ree-tay sor duh lah boosh day‿zahN-fahN)*

Literally: The truth comes out of children's mouths.

Meaning: Children often say simple true things that adults avoid.

English equivalent: Out of the mouths of babes.

Episode 14 · La carte postale (The postcard)

On Tuesday 23 June, Madame Rose's seventieth birthday, Rose is at the market and Hugo runs the Montmartre café alone. Juliette, the street's postwoman, comes in with the post, a camera hanging from her bag. Hugo's thick law textbook (Droit civil) lies open on the counter next to the till; later, Juliette sees it and turns Hugo's question back on him. Socrate tries to eat the postcard, so Hugo hides it in the sugar bowl, then puts the white cup on his side of the counter.

Juliette Bonjour ! Une carte pour Madame Rose. De Saint-Malo, comme chaque année.
Hello! A card for Madame Rose. From Saint-Malo, like every year. (neutral)

Hugo « Bon anniversaire, Rose. Tu cours encore ? O. »
'Happy birthday, Rose. Are you still running? O.' (curious)

Hugo O… Odette ! Elle est à Saint-Malo ! Elle écrit chaque année !
O… Odette! She's in Saint-Malo! She writes every year! (surprised)

Juliette Attention ! Socrate veut manger la carte !
Watch out! Socrate wants to eat the card! (amused)

Hugo Bon. Un café pour la factrice ? Ici, une question, puis un café.
Right. A coffee for the postwoman? Here: one question, then a coffee. (teasing)

Hugo Qu'est-ce que vous vouliez faire, quand vous étiez petite ?
What did you want to do when you were little? (curious)

Juliette Je voulais être photographe. Je prenais des photos de tout.
I wanted to be a photographer. I took photos of everything. (moved)

Hugo Mais vous avez un appareil photo ! Vous devriez essayer.
But you've got a camera! You should try. (hopeful)

Juliette Et vous, vous aimez le droit ?
And you, do you like law? (teasing)

Hugo Moi ? Euh… Mes parents aiment le droit.
Me? Er… My parents like law. (surprised)

Hugo Moi, j'aime faire des gâteaux…
What I like is making cakes… (sad)

Juliette C'est génial ! Vous devriez essayer, vous aussi.
That's great! You should try too. (hopeful)

Juliette Souriez ! Une photo avec la carte. Pour Madame Rose, pour ses soixante-dix ans.
Smile! A photo with the card. For Madame Rose, for her seventieth birthday. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **comme chaque année** *(kohm shahk ah-nay)* — like every year
- **Tu cours encore ?** *(tew koor ahN-kor)* — Are you still running? (tu: old friends)
- **Elle écrit chaque année** *(el ay-kree shahk ah-nay)* — She writes every year
- **Qu'est-ce que vous vouliez faire** *(kes-kuh voo voo-lyay fair)* — What did you want to do (vouliez: imparfait of vouloir)
- **Je voulais être photographe** *(zhuh voo-leh eh-truh foh-toh-grahf)* — I wanted to be a photographer (a past dream: imparfait)
- **Je prenais des photos** *(zhuh pruh-neh day foh-toh)* — I used to take photos (prendre: imparfait)
- **Vous devriez essayer** *(voo duh-vree-yay eh-seh-yay)* — You should try (advice)
- **vous aimez le droit** *(voo‿zeh-may luh drwah)* — you like law (le droit: law, the subject)
- **C'est génial !** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — That's great!
- **ses soixante-dix ans** *(say swah-sahNt-dee‿zahN)* — her seventieth birthday (ses: her, before a plural noun)

Notice: Imparfait or passé composé: je voulais, elle a écrit

Juliette describes her childhood dream: Je voulais être photographe. Je prenais des photos de tout. A dream or a habit in the past takes the imparfait, but one finished event takes the passé composé: Odette a écrit une carte. The postcard says Tu cours encore ? in tu because Odette and Rose are old friends; Hugo and Juliette say vous.

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Sagesse du jour

« Qui ne tente rien n'a rien. » *(kee nuh tahNt ryaN nah ryaN)*

Literally: Who tries nothing has nothing.

Meaning: If you never try, you never get anything.

English equivalent: Nothing ventured, nothing gained.

Episode 15 · Le portrait (The portrait)



On a Thursday in July, at half past five, the Montmartre café is almost closing. Karim, a portrait painter from the place du Tertre, sits at a table with his box of pencils closed. Rose puts the white cup on her side of the counter and looks at him over her glasses. While he draws her, Socrate sits perfectly still on her shoulder, posing like a statue.

Rose Bonjour, monsieur. On ferme bientôt.
Hello. We're closing soon. (neutral)

Karim Un thé, s'il vous plaît. Sans question.
A tea, please. No question. (sad)

Rose Sans question, sans thé.
No question, no tea. (teasing)

Karim Je peins dix touristes par jour. Je ne veux plus peindre.
I paint ten tourists a day. I don't want to paint any more. (US: anymore) (annoyed)

Rose Quand vous aviez dix ans, qui est-ce que vous dessiniez ?
When you were ten, who did you draw? (curious)

Karim Ma grand-mère. Je la dessinais tous les dimanches. Elle riait.
My grandmother. I drew her every Sunday. She used to laugh. (moved)

Rose Il faut commencer. Dessinez-moi.
You have to start. Draw me. (hopeful)

Karim Maintenant ? Ici ?
Now? Here? (worried)

Rose Pas mes rides, s'il vous plaît.
Not my wrinkles, please. (amused)

Rose Avant, je courais tout le temps. Une dame m'a arrêtée.
Before, I ran all the time. A lady stopped me. (neutral)

Karim Socrate ne bouge pas ! Et moi, j'ai envie de dessiner encore.
Socrate isn't moving! And I feel like drawing more. (amused)

Rose C'est pour moi ?
Is it for me? (moved)

Karim Oui. Je vous le donne. Ça me fait plaisir.
Yes. I'm giving it to you. It's my pleasure. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **Je ne veux plus peindre** *(zhuh nuh vuh plew paN-druh)* — I don't want to paint any more (ne… plus)
- **dix touristes** *(dee too-reest)* — ten tourists (dix before a consonant: the x is silent)
- **Quand vous aviez dix ans** *(kahN voo‿zah-vyay dee‿zahN)* — When you were ten (avoir for age, imparfait)
- **Je la dessinais** *(zhuh lah deh-see-neh)* — I used to draw her (la = her, before the verb)
- **Elle riait** *(el ree-yeh)* — She used to laugh (rire: imparfait)
- **Il faut commencer** *(eel foh koh-mahN-say)* — You have to start (il faut + infinitive)
- **je courais tout le temps** *(zhuh koo-reh too luh tahN)* — I used to run all the time (courir: imparfait)
- **j'ai envie de dessiner** *(zhay ahN-vee duh deh-see-nay)* — I feel like drawing (avoir envie de + infinitive)
- **Je vous le donne** *(zhuh voo luh dun)* — I'm giving it to you (le: it; vous: to you)
- **Ça me fait plaisir** *(sah muh feh pleh-zeer)* — It makes me happy / It's my pleasure

Notice: Object pronouns: je la dessinais, je vous le donne

Karim says Je la dessinais tous les dimanches: la replaces ma grand-mère and goes before the verb. Rose's Dessinez-moi is a command, so the pronoun goes after the verb and me becomes moi. In Je vous le donne, le (the drawing) is the direct object and vous is indirect, because you give something to someone (donner quelque chose à quelqu'un).

See the table: Grammar tables, Direct object pronouns: me, le, la...

Sagesse du jour

« L'appétit vient en mangeant. » *(lah-pay-tee vyaN ahN mahN-zhahN)*

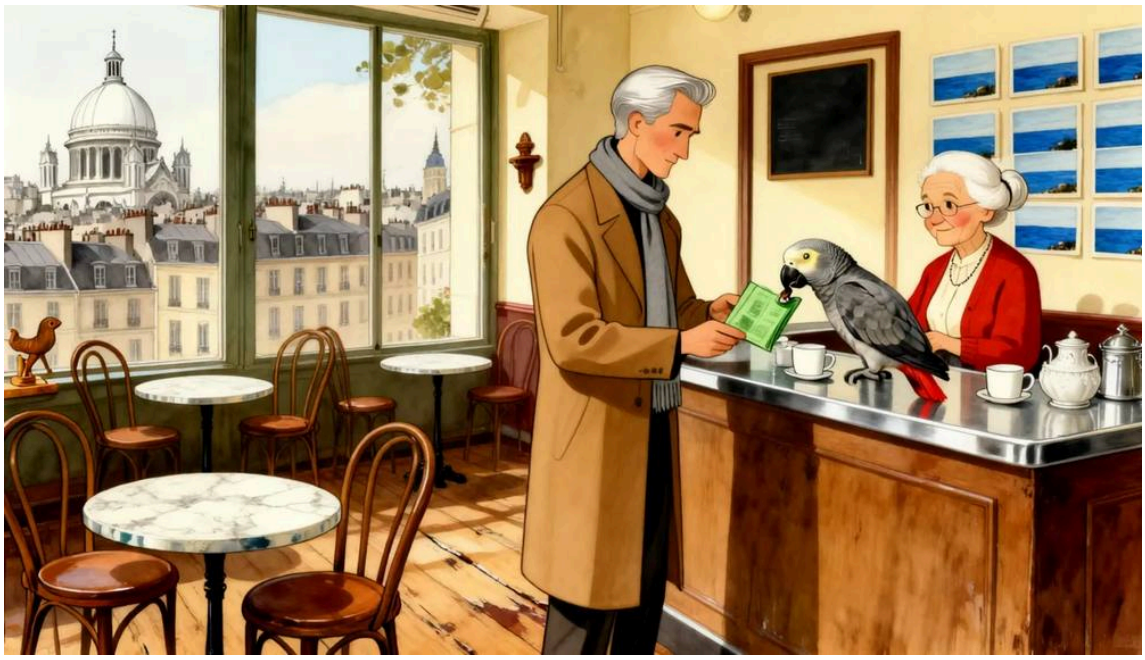
Literally: Appetite comes while eating.

Meaning: Once you start doing something, the desire to do it grows.

Act 4 · Les réponses (The answers)

Level B1

Episode 16 · Cent euros (A hundred euros)



On a Thursday in September Frédéric, in a perfect coat, walks into Madame Rose's tiny Montmartre café and puts a hundred-euro note on the counter: he has heard about the rule and would like to skip it. Socrate the grey parrot hops down from his perch and nibbles one corner of the note. Rose pulls the white cup back to her side of the counter and looks at him over her glasses.

Frédéric Bonjour, madame. Je voudrais un café. Sans la question. Voilà cent euros.
Hello. I'd like a coffee. Without the question. Here's a hundred euros. (proud)

Rose Vous avez de la monnaie ? Le café coûte deux euros. La question est gratuite.
Have you got any change? The coffee costs two euros. The question is free. (teasing)

Frédéric Alors, j'achète l'ardoise. Ou le perroquet, même s'il coûte les yeux de la tête !
Then I'll buy the slate. Or the parrot, even if it costs an arm and a leg! (literally: the eyes of the head) (annoyed)

Rose Regardez Socrate. Il mange le coin de votre billet !
Look at Socrate. He's eating the corner of your note! (US: bill) (amused)

Rose Qui est-ce que vous aimeriez appeler ce soir ?
Who would you like to call tonight? (curious)

Frédéric Personne… Personne ne m'appelle. Mon téléphone ne sonne jamais.
Nobody… Nobody calls me. My phone never rings. (sad)

Frédéric Mon frère, Marc, habite à Lyon. On ne s'appelle plus depuis dix ans.
My brother, Marc, lives in Lyon. We haven't phoned each other for ten years. (sad)

Frédéric Une histoire d'argent. La maison de nos parents. C'est bête.
It was about money. Our parents' house. It's silly. (annoyed)

Rose Le plus beau cadeau de ma vie ? C'était une question.
The best present of my life? It was a question. (US: gift) (moved)

Frédéric Je voudrais l'appeler. J'aimerais lui dire pardon.
I'd like to call him. I'd like to say sorry to him. (hopeful)

Rose On pourrait commencer par un café, non ?
We could start with a coffee, couldn't we? (teasing)

Frédéric Merci, madame. Je paie : deux euros. Et… mon billet ?
Thank you. I'm paying: two euros. And… my note? (US: bill) (relieved)

Rose Reprenez votre billet. Il n'est pas à vendre, mon perroquet.
Take your note back. My parrot is not for sale. (US: bill) (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Je voudrais un café** *(zhuh voo-dreh uhN kah-fay)* — I'd like a coffee (polite)
- **cent euros** *(sahN‿tuh-roh)* — a hundred euros (t liaison: cent euros)
- **j'achète l'ardoise** *(zhah-shet lar-dwahz)* — I'll buy the slate (acheter: j'achète)
- **coûte les yeux de la tête** *(koot lay‿zyuh duh lah tet)* — costs an arm and a leg (literally: the eyes of the head)
- **Qui est-ce que vous aimeriez appeler** *(kee es-kuh voo‿zeh-muh-ryay ah-puh-lay)* — Who would you like to call (a wish: conditional)
- **Personne ne m'appelle** *(pair-sun nuh mah-pel)* — Nobody calls me (appeler: two l before a silent e)
- **Je voudrais l'appeler** *(zhuh voo-dreh lah-puh-lay)* — I'd like to call him (vouloir, polite)
- **J'aimerais lui dire pardon** *(zhem-reh lwee deer par-dohN)* — I'd like to say sorry to him (aimer, a wish)
- **On pourrait commencer** *(ohN poo-reh koh-mahN-say)* — We could start (pouvoir, a soft suggestion)
- **Je paie** *(zhuh peh)* — I'm paying (payer)

Notice: Polite and wishing forms: je voudrais, j'aimerais, on pourrait

Frédéric orders with Je voudrais un café and later says J'aimerais lui dire pardon. Rose asks Qui est-ce que vous aimeriez appeler ? and suggests On pourrait commencer par un café. These conditional forms soften a request, state a wish or make a gentle suggestion; Je veux un café is much blunter.

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Sagesse du jour

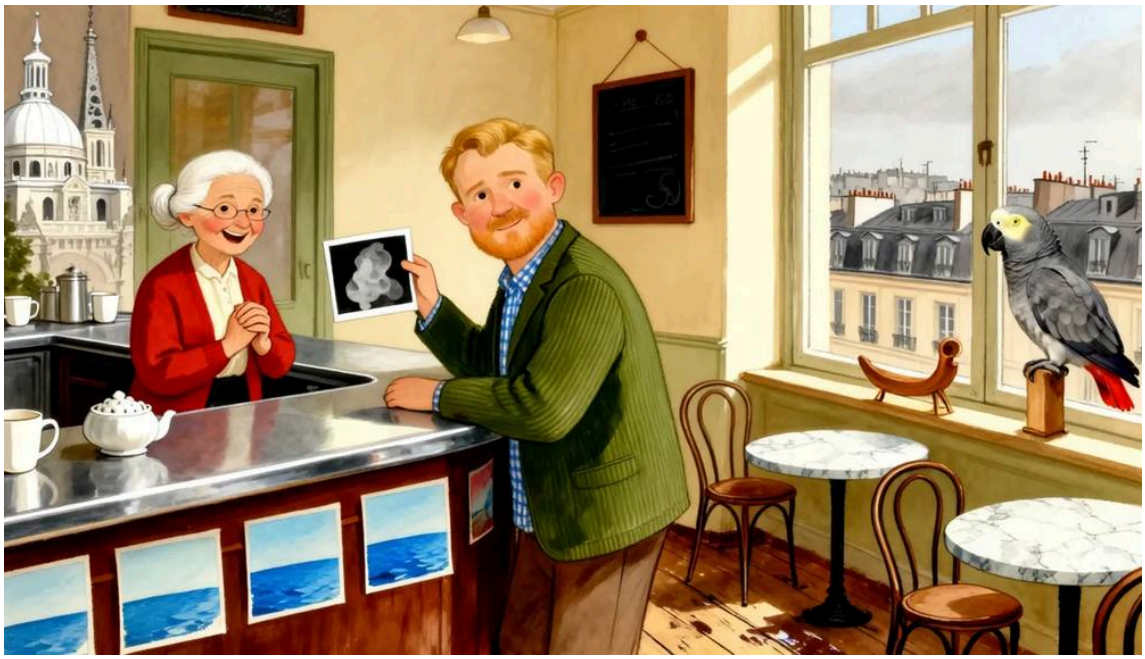
« L'argent ne fait pas le bonheur. » *(lar-zhahN nuh feh pah luh bu-nuhr)*

Literally: Money doesn't make happiness.

Meaning: Being rich doesn't make you happy.

English equivalent: Money can't buy happiness.

Episode 17 · Tel père… (Like father…)



On a Friday in September Paul, the groom from March, comes back to Madame Rose's tiny Montmartre café. He is holding a small black-and-white scan picture: his wife Léa is expecting a baby in December. Rose puts the white cup on her side of the counter, and Socrate watches from his perch by the window.

Paul Bonjour, madame Rose ! Vous vous souvenez de moi ? Le discours de trois phrases !
Hello, Madame Rose! Do you remember me? The three-sentence speech! (proud)

Rose Bien sûr ! Le discours le plus court de Paris. Et Léa, ça va ?
Of course! The shortest speech in Paris. And how's Léa? (amused)

Paul Très bien. Regardez cette photo… Léa attend un bébé. Il va naître en décembre !
Very well. Look at this picture… Léa's expecting a baby. It's due in December! (proud)

Rose Un bébé ! C'est génial ! Félicitations, monsieur Paul !
A baby! That's brilliant! Congratulations, Paul! (surprised)

Paul Merci. Mais j'ai peur. Mon père n'était jamais là. Il travaillait tout le temps.
Thank you. But I'm scared. My father was never there. He worked all the time. (worried)

Paul Tel père, tel fils, non ?
Like father, like son, right? (sad)

Rose Quel père est-ce que vous aimeriez être ?
What kind of father would you like to be? (curious)

Paul Le père que je voudrais être ? Un père qui est là.
The father I'd like to be? A father who's there. (hopeful)

Paul Qui joue. Qui pose des questions.
Who plays. Who asks questions. (hopeful)

Rose Mon père voulait une avocate. Il a eu une patronne de café.
My father wanted a lawyer for a daughter. He got a café owner. (amused)

Rose Mais il venait chaque dimanche pour la tarte.
But he came every Sunday for the tart. (moved)

Rose Alors, tel père, tel fils… c'est vous qui choisissez le père.
So, like father, like son… but you're the one who chooses the father. (hopeful)

Paul J'aimerais l'appeler Rose… si c'est une fille.
I'd like to call her Rose… if it's a girl. (moved)

Rose Regardez Socrate, il vous tourne le dos ! Socrate voudrait Socrate.
Look at Socrate, he's turning his back on you! Socrate would rather it was called Socrate. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Vous vous souvenez de moi** *(voo voo soo-vuh-nay duh mwah)* — Do you remember me? (se souvenir de)
- **Il va naître** *(eel vah neh-truh)* — It's going to be born (naître, near future)
- **en décembre** *(ahN day-sahN-bruh)* — in December (en + month)
- **C'est génial** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — That's brilliant
- **Il travaillait tout le temps** *(eel trah-vah-yeh too luh tahN)* — He worked all the time (imparfait: a habit)
- **Quel père est-ce que vous aimeriez être** *(kel pair es-kuh voo‿zeh-muh-ryay eh-truh)* — What kind of father would you like to be (a wish)
- **Le père que je voudrais être** *(luh pair kuh zhuh voo-dreh eh-truh)* — The father I'd like to be (que: not the subject)
- **Un père qui est là** *(uhN pair kee eh lah)* — A father who's there (qui: the subject)
- **c'est vous qui choisissez** *(seh voo kee shwah-zee-say)* — you're the one who chooses (choisir)

Notice: Qui and que: un père qui est là

Paul says Le père que je voudrais être ? Un père qui est là. Qui is the subject of its clause (the father is there), so a verb follows it directly; que is used when the clause already has its own subject, here je. Rose uses qui too: c'est vous qui choisissez le père.

See the table: Grammar tables, Relative pronouns: qui, que, où, dont.

Sagesse du jour

« Tel père, tel fils. » *(tel pair, tel fees)*

Literally: Such father, such son.

Meaning: Children often grow up like their parents.

English equivalent: Like father, like son.

Episode 18 · L'histoire de Rose (Rose's story)

On Friday at six, closing time, the chairs are up on the three little tables of Madame Rose's Montmartre café. Hugo, her great-nephew, has taken down the postcards to dust them: forty cards of the sea, all signed O. Rose sits down with her blue cup, and Socrate sleeps on the counter.

Hugo Quarante cartes, Tata. Et toujours la même question ?
Forty cards, Auntie. And always the same question? (curious)

Rose Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
Here, I'm the one who asks the questions. (teasing)

Hugo Il n'y a pas de clients. C'est fermé.
There are no customers. We're closed. (teasing)

Rose Bon. Assieds-toi. Tu sais pourquoi j'ai gardé cette règle ?
Right. Sit down. Do you know why I kept this rule? (curious)

Hugo Non. Tu n'en dis jamais rien.
No. You never say anything about it. (curious)

Rose À vingt-deux ans, j'étais étudiante en droit. Je courais partout.
At twenty-two, I was a law student. I ran everywhere. (neutral)

Rose Un matin, Odette m'a demandé : « Pourquoi vous courez ? »
One morning, Odette asked me: 'Why are you running?' (moved)

Rose Je lui ai répondu : « Parce que je suis en retard. » — « En retard pour quoi ? »
I answered: 'Because I'm late.' And she said: 'Late for what?' (amused)

Rose Je n'avais pas de réponse. Je me suis assise. Je suis restée une heure.
I had no answer. I sat down. I stayed an hour. (moved)

Rose J'ai quitté le droit. En quatre-vingt-six, elle m'a laissé le café, la tarte et Socrate.
I gave up law. In '86 she left me the café, the tart and Socrate. (proud)

Rose « Il aime le café, pas la mer. » Rien ne sert de courir… tu connais la suite ?
'He loves the café, not the sea,' she said. There's no point running… do you know the rest? (amused)

Hugo Il faut partir à point. Mais pourquoi tu n'y es jamais allée, à Saint-Malo ?
You have to set off at the right time. But why have you never been there, to Saint-Malo? (curious)

Rose Je… Le café ne peut pas attendre.
I… The café can't wait. (surprised)

Hugo Un café, ça réveille. Une question, ça réveille plus.
A coffee wakes you up. A question wakes you up more. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **Tu n'en dis jamais rien** *(tew nahN dee zhah-meh ryaN)* — You never say anything about it (en = about it)
- **j'étais étudiante en droit** *(zhay-teh ay-tew-dyahNt ahN drwah)* — I was a law student (imparfait: description)
- **Je courais partout** *(zhuh koo-reh par-too)* — I ran everywhere (courir, imparfait: a habit)
- **Parce que je suis en retard** *(pars kuh zhuh swee‿zahN ruh-tar)* — Because I'm late
- **Je me suis assise** *(zhuh muh swee ah-seez)* — I sat down (s'asseoir; assise: Rose is a woman)
- **Je suis restée une heure** *(zhuh swee res-tay ewn uhr)* — I stayed an hour (rester takes être)
- **J'ai quitté le droit** *(zhay kee-tay luh drwah)* — I gave up law (quitter: to leave a place, a job, studies)
- **elle m'a laissé le café** *(el mah leh-say luh kah-fay)* — she left me the café (laisser: to leave something to someone)
- **tu n'y es jamais allée** *(tew nee eh zhah-meh ah-lay)* — you've never been there (y = to Saint-Malo)

Notice: En and y: tu n'en dis rien, tu n'y es jamais allée

Hugo says Tu n'en dis jamais rien: en stands for 'about it' (de cette histoire). Then he asks Pourquoi tu n'y es jamais allée, à Saint-Malo ?: y stands for 'there' (à Saint-Malo), and both go before the verb. Notice too that in 1978 Odette said vous to Rose (Pourquoi vous courez ?), a customer she didn't know yet; today her cards say tu.

See the table: Grammar tables, Y and en.

Sagesse du jour

« Rien ne sert de courir ; il faut partir à point. » *(ryaN nuh sair duh koo-reer, eel foh par-teer ah pwaN)*

Literally: Running is no use; you must set off at the right time.

Meaning: Rushing doesn't help; start calmly, at the right moment.

English equivalent: Slow and steady wins the race.

Episode 19 · Pourquoi tu cours ? (Why are you running?)



On Saturday at a quarter past eight Hugo runs into the café with a law textbook under his arm: he revised all night for Monday's exam. Madame Rose is waiting at the counter with her blue cup and a white one. She pours his coffee and keeps it on her side. Later she takes a card from the drawer under the till.

Rose Huit heures et quart, mon grand.
A quarter past eight, my boy. (teasing)

Hugo J'arrive ! Pardon, Tata ! Je suis en retard !
Coming! Sorry, Auntie! I'm late! (worried)

Rose Pourquoi tu cours ?
Why are you running? (curious)

Hugo Parce que je suis en retard.
Because I'm late. (neutral)

Rose En retard pour quoi ?
Late for what? (neutral)

Hugo Parce que… le droit, c'est bien ?
Because… law is good? (amused)

Rose Regarde Socrate. Il te tourne le dos.
Look at Socrate. He's turning his back on you. (teasing)

Hugo Attends… Tu m'as posé la question d'Odette.
Wait… You've just asked me Odette's question. (surprised)

Hugo J'aimerais être pâtissier. Je voudrais faire un CAP. Mais mes parents…
I'd like to be a pastry chef. I'd like to do a CAP (a vocational diploma). But my parents… (sad)

Rose C'est ta vie, mon grand. Et c'est une bonne idée.
It's your life, my boy. And it's a good idea. (hopeful)

Hugo Tu as raison. Je vais le dire à mes parents. Ce soir.
You're right. I'm going to tell my parents. Tonight. (proud)

Rose Voilà la recette d'Odette. Elle est à toi, maintenant.
Here's Odette's recipe. It's yours now. (moved)

Hugo Merci, Tata. Et… mon café ?
Thanks, Auntie. And… my coffee? (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Huit heures et quart** *(wee‿tuhr ay kar)* — A quarter past eight (t liaison after huit; none after et)
- **J'arrive** *(zhah-reev)* — Coming! / I'm on my way
- **Je suis en retard** *(zhuh swee‿zahN ruh-tar)* — I'm late
- **Pourquoi tu cours** *(poor-kwah tew koor)* — Why are you running? (courir: tu cours)
- **J'aimerais être pâtissier** *(zhem-reh eh-truh pah-tee-syay)* — I'd like to be a pastry chef (a wish; no article before the job)
- **Je voudrais faire un CAP** *(zhuh voo-dreh fair uhN say-ah-pay)* — I'd like to do a CAP (a vocational diploma)
- **C'est ta vie** *(seh tah vee)* — It's your life (c'est + ta + noun)
- **Je vais le dire à mes parents** *(zhuh veh luh deer ah may pah-rahN)* — I'm going to tell my parents (dire, near future)
- **Elle est à toi** *(el eh ah twah)* — It's yours (à toi: stressed pronoun)

Notice: C'est ta vie, but il est pâtissier

Rose says C'est ta vie and C'est une bonne idée: c'est comes before a determiner (ta, une) and a noun. For a job after être, French uses no article: Hugo says J'aimerais être pâtissier, and you say Il est pâtissier or Il est étudiant.

See the table: Grammar tables, C'est or il est?

Sagesse du jour

« Vouloir, c'est pouvoir. » *(voo-lwahr, seh poo-vwahr)*

Literally: To want is to be able.

Meaning: If you really want something, you find a way.

English equivalent: Where there's a will, there's a way.

Episode 20 · La question pour Rose (The question for Rose)



On Saturday 17 October Thomas, the man in a hurry from the first episode, walks slowly into Madame Rose's Montmartre café, with no phone. Hugo, silent behind the counter, has told him Rose's story, and Thomas pushes the white cup across to Rose's side. When Thomas says that Socrate likes travelling, the grey parrot whistles for the first time in years: his yes to Saint-Malo. At the end Rose picks up the chalk and writes two sentences on the slate, under Odette's rule.

Thomas Bonjour, madame Rose. Aujourd'hui, c'est moi qui pose la question.
Good morning, Madame Rose. Today, I'm the one asking the question. (proud)

Rose Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
Here, I'm the one who asks the questions. (teasing)

Thomas Pas aujourd'hui.
Not today. (teasing)

Rose Vous marchez, maintenant ?
So you walk now? (teasing)

Thomas Je marche. Chaque chose en son temps. Et vous, madame Rose, qu'est-ce que vous aimeriez ?
I walk. All in good time. And you, Madame Rose, what would you like? (curious)

Rose Moi ? Personne ne me pose jamais la question.
Me? Nobody ever asks me that. (surprised)

Rose J'aimerais revoir Odette. Lui dire merci. Et voir la mer.
I'd like to see Odette again. To say thank you. And to see the sea. (moved)

Thomas Saint-Malo, c'est à deux heures et demie de train.
Saint-Malo is two and a half hours by train. (neutral)

Rose Et le café ? Et Socrate ?
And the café? And Socrate? (worried)

Thomas Hugo est là. Et Socrate aime les voyages, non ?
Hugo's here. And Socrate likes travelling, doesn't he? (US: traveling) (amused)

Rose Il a sifflé ! Il ne siffle jamais !
He whistled! He never whistles! (surprised)

Rose On pourrait partir lundi… À quelle heure part le train ?
We could leave on Monday… What time does the train leave? (hopeful)

Thomas À huit heures.
At eight o'clock. (neutral)

Rose Lundi, c'est Hugo. Je vais répondre à une question. Votre café. Aujourd'hui, sans question.
On Monday, Hugo's in charge. I'm going to answer a question. Your coffee. Today, no question. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **c'est moi qui pose la question** *(seh mwah kee pohz lah kes-tyohN)* — I'm the one asking the question (poser une question)
- **Vous marchez** *(voo mar-shay)* — You walk (marcher)
- **qu'est-ce que vous aimeriez** *(kes-kuh voo‿zeh-muh-ryay)* — what would you like (a wish: conditional)
- **J'aimerais revoir Odette** *(zhem-reh ruh-vwahr oh-det)* — I'd like to see Odette again (aimer, a wish)
- **voir la mer** *(vwahr lah mair)* — to see the sea (voir)
- **deux heures et demie** *(duh‿zuhr ay duh-mee)* — two and a half hours (z liaison after deux)
- **On pourrait partir lundi** *(ohN poo-reh par-teer luhN-dee)* — We could leave on Monday (a soft suggestion)
- **À quelle heure part le train** *(ah kel uhr par luh traN)* — What time does the train leave?
- **À quelle heure** *(ah kel uhr)* — At what time (quelle: heure is feminine)

Notice: Wishing: vous aimeriez, j'aimerais, on pourrait

Thomas asks Qu'est-ce que vous aimeriez ? and Rose answers J'aimerais revoir Odette. Aimer in the conditional states a wish, and On pourrait partir lundi… makes a soft suggestion. Compare the present J'aime la mer: a fact, not a wish.

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Sagesse du jour

« Tout est bien qui finit bien. » *(too‿teh byaN kee fee-nee byaN)*

Literally: All is well that ends well.

Meaning: A happy ending makes the difficulties worth it.

English equivalent: All's well that ends well.

Questions

Episode 1 · La règle

1. Why does Thomas want his coffee quickly?
   a. He has a train to catch
   b. He's cold
   c. He's late
   d. He's very tired
2. What does Thomas like in the morning?
   a. Bread and jam
   b. Coffee and silence
   c. His phones and his work
   d. Running and music
3. How long does Thomas stay in the end?
   a. An hour
   b. Five minutes
   c. Ten minutes
   d. Two minutes
4. What is Rose's question?
   a. Où est-ce que vous travaillez ?
   b. Pourquoi vous êtes en retard ?
   c. Qu'est-ce que vous aimez, le matin ?
   d. Qu'est-ce que vous buvez, le matin ?

Episode 2 · Le discours

1. Why is Paul so pale?
   a. He has lost the wedding rings
   b. He has no money for the tea
   c. He's ill
   d. He's scared of his wedding speech
2. How many pages is Paul's speech at first?
   a. Ten
   b. Twelve
   c. Twenty
   d. Two
3. Why does Paul love Léa?
   a. She cooks and she sings
   b. She laughs all the time and she's kind
   c. She works with him at school
   d. She's rich and very pretty
4. What is Rose's question?
   a. Où est votre discours ?
   b. Pourquoi vous aimez Léa ?
   c. Pourquoi vous êtes tout blanc ?
   d. Quand est-ce que vous vous mariez ?

Episode 3 · Le petit-neveu

1. How much does Rose say the broken cup costs?
   a. Five euros
   b. Nothing
   c. Three euros
   d. Two euros
2. Why does Hugo think he should get his coffee without a question?
   a. He broke a cup
   b. He's family
   c. He's late
   d. He's very tired
3. What does Hugo like doing?
   a. Baking cakes
   b. Making coffee
   c. Running
   d. Studying law
4. What does Rose say when Hugo asks how old the café is?
   a. Cinquante ans !
   b. Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
   c. La règle, c'est la règle.
   d. Pas de problème.

Episode 4 · Un jour à Paris

1. Why does Emma want her coffee quickly?
   a. She has a plan for the day
   b. She's cold
   c. She's late for her train
   d. She's meeting a friend
2. What does Emma see through the window?
   a. The Eiffel Tower and the river
   b. The Louvre and a park
   c. The market and Rose
   d. The roofs and the Sacré-Cœur
3. Where do the postcards behind the counter come from?
   a. London
   b. Lyon
   c. Manchester
   d. Saint-Malo
4. What is Hugo's first, silly question?
   a. Qu'est-ce que vous voyez, là ?
   b. Votre couleur préférée ?
   c. Votre plan préféré ?
   d. Vous venez d'où ?

Episode 5 · Monsieur Oui

1. What does Antoine say before Rose speaks?
   a. A coffee, please!
   b. No, thank you!
   c. Sorry, I'm late!
   d. Yes, yes, OK!
2. Whose rule is it, according to Rose?
   a. A friend's
   b. Her mother's
   c. Rose's
   d. Socrate's
3. How much is a slice of tart?
   a. Five euros
   b. Four euros
   c. Three euros
   d. Two euros
4. What does Antoine really not want?
   a. Je ne veux pas aider ma sœur !
   b. Je ne veux pas boire de café !
   c. Je ne veux pas garder le chien !
   d. Je ne veux pas manger de tarte !

Episode 6 · Le permis

1. Why is Léo surprised at the start?
   a. Rose calls him vous
   b. Rose knows his name
   c. The hot chocolate is free
   d. The parrot speaks to him
2. What went wrong in Léo's driving test?
   a. He arrived late and missed the test
   b. He forgot his papers and went home
   c. He hit a car and the examiner left
   d. He pulled away too fast and the examiner shouted
3. How old is Léo?
   a. Eighteen
   b. Seventeen
   c. Sixteen
   d. Twenty
4. What is Rose's question?
   a. Pourquoi vous êtes parti trop vite ?
   b. Qu'est-ce que vous allez faire en juin ?
   c. Qu'est-ce que vous avez appris ce matin ?
   d. Qu'est-ce que vous avez raté ce matin ?

Episode 7 · L'influenceur

1. What does Rose want Max to do first?
    a. Pay for his coffee
    b. Say hello to her
    c. Sit down at a table
    d. Turn off his phone
2. How many followers does Max have?
    a. 2 million
    b. 2,000
    c. 20,000
    d. 200,000
3. What does Socrate do when Max wants a selfie?
    a. He bites Max's phone
    b. He fluffs up his feathers
    c. He steals a sugar cube
    d. He turns his back on him
4. What does Max realise about his day?
    a. Je n'ai pas aimé Paris.
    b. Je n'ai pas filmé le café.
    c. Je n'ai pas pris de photos.
    d. Je n'ai pas regardé Paris.

Episode 8 · Le vélo

1. How does Bruno explain why he looks sad?
    a. He has lost his job
    b. He's late for work
    c. His bike is broken
    d. It's Monday
2. How long has Bruno worked in insurance?
    a. Fifteen years
    b. Thirty-five years
    c. Twenty years
    d. Twenty-five years
3. What made Bruno happy last week?
    a. A day off at home
    b. Lunch with his neighbour
    c. Repairing his neighbour's bike
    d. Riding his new bike
4. What is Bruno going to do?
    a. Acheter un vélo neuf
    b. Appeler son voisin
    c. Passer au magasin de vélos
    d. Rester au bureau

Episode 9 · L'appel

1. Why is Inès tired?
   a. She danced all night
   b. She drove all night
   c. She read all night
   d. She worked all night
2. Why does Hugo wear Auntie Rose's glasses?
   a. Because his are broken
   b. To look like a doctor
   c. To look serious
   d. To read the slate
3. When did Inès and her mother fall out?
   a. Three days ago
   b. Three months ago
   c. Three weeks ago
   d. Three years ago
4. What does Inès decide to do?
   a. Je vais l'appeler tout de suite.
   b. Je vais l'attendre encore.
   c. Je vais lui écrire dimanche.
   d. Je vais rentrer dormir.

Episode 10 · La vieille photo

1. Why does Victor ask so many questions?
   a. He is a police detective
   b. He is writing a guidebook to Paris
   c. He wants to buy the café
   d. He writes a blog about old Montmartre
2. What does Socrate do after the fifth question?
   a. He bites Victor's notebook
   b. He fluffs up his feathers
   c. He steals Victor's sugar
   d. He turns his back on Victor
3. What did Victor's wife say to him this morning?
   a. He doesn't know: he didn't listen
   b. To buy some bread
   c. To come home early
   d. To stop writing his blog
4. What is the café called in Victor's photo?
   a. Chez Odette
   b. Chez Rose
   c. Chez Socrate
   d. Le Café des Questions

Episode 11 · Le bal du samedi

1. Who is Albert?
   a. A painter from the place du Tertre
   b. Odette's brother
   c. Rose's old teacher
   d. The street's old postman
2. How did young Rose drink her coffee, according to Albert?
   a. At a table, with a book
   b. Sitting by the window, slowly
   c. Standing up, always in a hurry
   d. With Odette, every Sunday
3. How old is Albert?
   a. Eighty-two
   b. Ninety-two
   c. Seventy-two
   d. Sixty-eight
4. What is Rose's question?
   a. Où est-ce que vous habitiez avant Rouen ?
   b. Pourquoi vous êtes revenu à Montmartre ?
   c. Qu'est-ce que vous aimez faire le dimanche ?
   d. Qu'est-ce que vous aimiez faire le samedi soir ?

Episode 12 · Le gâteau brûlé

1. What happened to Nadia's cake?
   a. It burnt, twice
   b. It fell on the floor
   c. She left it at home
   d. Socrate ate half of it
2. How old will Lina be on Saturday?
   a. Eight
   b. Eighteen
   c. Six
   d. Ten
3. What did Lina love when she was little?
   a. Bread and jam
   b. Her grandmother's apple tart
   c. Her mother's chocolate cake
   d. Strawberries with sugar
4. What does Hugo advise Nadia?
   a. Vous devriez acheter un gâteau.
   b. Vous devriez demander à Madame Rose.
   c. Vous devriez faire une tarte aux pommes.
   d. Vous devriez refaire le gâteau du magazine.

Episode 13 · Pourquoi, pourquoi, pourquoi

1. How old is Samuel's son?
    a. Eight
    b. Four
    c. Six
    d. Ten
2. What did Samuel's father use to answer?
    a. 'Ask your mother.'
    b. 'Because.'
    c. 'I don't know.'
    d. 'Later.'
3. What did Rose do when she was young, instead of asking questions?
    a. She danced
    b. She painted
    c. She ran
    d. She read
4. What is Samuel going to ask his son?
    a. Et toi ?
    b. Et vous ?
    c. Parce que.
    d. Pourquoi ?

Episode 14 · La carte postale

1. Where does the postcard for Rose come from?
    a. Lyon
    b. Manchester
    c. Rouen
    d. Saint-Malo
2. What does Hugo discover about Odette?
    a. She is coming to Paris for the birthday
    b. She lives in Saint-Malo and writes every year
    c. She sends Hugo a card every year
    d. She works at the post office in Montmartre
3. What did Juliette want to be as a child?
    a. A lawyer
    b. A painter
    c. A pastry chef
    d. A photographer
4. What does Hugo really like doing?
    a. Faire des gâteaux.
    b. Prendre des photos.
    c. Écrire des cartes.
    d. Étudier le droit.

Episode 15 · Le portrait

1. How many tourists does Karim paint a day?
   a. Five
   b. Ten
   c. Twenty
   d. Two
2. Who did Karim draw when he was a child?
   a. His brother, at school
   b. His dog, every morning
   c. His grandmother, every Sunday
   d. His mother, every evening
3. What does Rose tell Karim about her past?
   a. She drew her grandmother every Sunday
   b. She used to paint portraits on the place du Tertre
   c. She used to run all the time, until a lady stopped her
   d. She worked at the post office in Montmartre
4. What does Karim say when he gives Rose the drawing?
   a. Ça m'est égal.
   b. Ça me fait peur.
   c. Ça me fait plaisir.
   d. Ça ne me plaît pas.

Episode 16 · Cent euros

1. How much does Frédéric offer to skip the question?
   a. A hundred euros
   b. Fifty euros
   c. Twenty euros
   d. Two hundred euros
2. Where does Frédéric's brother live?
   a. In Lyon
   b. In Marseille
   c. In Paris
   d. In Saint-Malo
3. Why don't Frédéric and Marc phone each other?
   a. Frédéric lost his number
   b. Marc moved abroad
   c. They quarrelled about money
   d. They quarrelled about work
4. What is Rose's question?
   a. Pourquoi vous voulez payer cent euros ?
   b. Qu'est-ce que vous aimeriez acheter ce soir ?
   c. Qui est-ce que vous aimeriez appeler ce soir ?
   d. Qui est-ce que vous aimeriez voir ce soir ?

Episode 17 · Tel père…

1. What is Paul's news?
   a. Léa has a new job
   b. Léa is expecting a baby
   c. Paul has a new school
   d. They are moving to Lyon
2. When is the baby due?
   a. In December
   b. In March
   c. In October
   d. In September
3. Why is Paul afraid?
   a. He thinks he is too young
   b. He works too much at school
   c. His father was never there
   d. His father was very strict
4. What father would Paul like to be?
   a. Un père comme le sien.
   b. Un père qui est là.
   c. Un père qui travaille beaucoup.
   d. Un père très sévère.

Episode 18 · L'histoire de Rose

1. What was Rose at twenty-two?
   a. A law student
   b. A medical student
   c. A primary-school teacher
   d. A waitress at Odette's
2. What did Rose do after Odette's question?
   a. She paid and left at once
   b. She phoned her father
   c. She ran to her lecture
   d. She sat down and stayed an hour
3. In which year did Odette leave Rose the café?
   a. 1962
   b. 1975
   c. 1978
   d. 1986
4. What was Odette's question?
   a. Où est-ce que vous allez ?
   b. Pourquoi vous courez ?
   c. Pourquoi vous êtes en retard ?
   d. Qu'est-ce que vous aimez ?

Episode 19 · Pourquoi tu cours ?

1. What time does Hugo arrive?
   a. At a quarter past eight
   b. At a quarter to nine
   c. At eight o'clock
   d. At half past eight
2. What does Socrate do when Hugo says law is good?
   a. He fluffs up his feathers
   b. He steals a sugar cube
   c. He turns his back on Hugo
   d. He whistles
3. What would Hugo like to be?
   a. A lawyer
   b. A painter
   c. A pastry chef
   d. A teacher
4. What does Rose give Hugo?
   a. La clé du café.
   b. La recette d'Odette.
   c. La tasse bleue d'Odette.
   d. Une carte de Saint-Malo.

Episode 20 · La question pour Rose

1. What has changed about Thomas?
   a. He drinks tea now
   b. He has a new phone
   c. He walks now, slowly
   d. He works in Lyon now
2. What would Rose like to do?
   a. Buy a new slate
   b. Close the café for a month
   c. See Odette again and see the sea
   d. Visit her sister in Lyon
3. How long is the train journey to Saint-Malo?
   a. Eight hours
   b. Four hours
   c. One and a half hours
   d. Two and a half hours
4. What is Thomas's question for Rose?
   a. Et vous, madame Rose, où est-ce que vous allez ?
   b. Et vous, madame Rose, pourquoi vous courez ?
   c. Et vous, madame Rose, qu'est-ce que vous aimeriez ?
   d. Et vous, madame Rose, qu'est-ce que vous aimez ?

Answer key

1.1 c) He's late
1.2 b) Coffee and silence
1.3 b) Five minutes
1.4 c) Qu'est-ce que vous aimez, le matin ?
2.1 d) He's scared of his wedding speech
2.2 b) Twelve
2.3 b) She laughs all the time and she's kind
2.4 b) Pourquoi vous aimez Léa ?
3.1 d) Two euros
3.2 b) He's family
3.3 a) Baking cakes
3.4 b) Ici, c'est moi qui pose les questions.
4.1 a) She has a plan for the day
4.2 d) The roofs and the Sacré-Cœur
4.3 d) Saint-Malo
4.4 b) Votre couleur préférée ?
5.1 d) Yes, yes, OK!
5.2 a) A friend's
5.3 a) Five euros
5.4 c) Je ne veux pas garder le chien !
6.1 a) Rose calls him vous
6.2 d) He pulled away too fast and the examiner shouted
6.3 b) Seventeen
6.4 c) Qu'est-ce que vous avez appris ce matin ?
7.1 b) Say hello to her
7.2 d) 200,000
7.3 d) He turns his back on him
7.4 d) Je n'ai pas regardé Paris.
8.1 d) It's Monday
8.2 d) Twenty-five years
8.3 c) Repairing his neighbour's bike
8.4 c) Passer au magasin de vélos
9.1 d) She worked all night
9.2 c) To look serious
9.3 b) Three months ago
9.4 a) Je vais l'appeler tout de suite.
10.1 d) He writes a blog about old Montmartre
10.2 d) He turns his back on Victor
10.3 a) He doesn't know: he didn't listen
10.4 a) Chez Odette
11.1 d) The street's old postman
11.2 c) Standing up, always in a hurry
11.3 a) Eighty-two
11.4 d) Qu'est-ce que vous aimiez faire le samedi soir ?
12.1 a) It burnt, twice
12.2 a) Eight
12.3 b) Her grandmother's apple tart
12.4 c) Vous devriez faire une tarte aux pommes.
13.1 c) Six
13.2 b) 'Because.'
13.3 c) She ran
13.4 a) Et toi ?
14.1 d) Saint-Malo
14.2 b) She lives in Saint-Malo and writes every year
14.3 d) A photographer
14.4 a) Faire des gâteaux.
15.1 b) Ten
15.2 c) His grandmother, every Sunday
15.3 c) She used to run all the time, until a lady stopped her
15.4 c) Ça me fait plaisir.
16.1 a) A hundred euros
16.2 a) In Lyon
16.3 c) They quarrelled about money
16.4 c) Qui est-ce que vous aimeriez appeler ce soir ?
17.1 b) Léa is expecting a baby
17.2 a) In December
17.3 c) His father was never there
17.4 b) Un père qui est là.
18.1 a) A law student
18.2 d) She sat down and stayed an hour
18.3 d) 1986
18.4 b) Pourquoi vous courez ?
19.1 a) At a quarter past eight
19.2 c) He turns his back on Hugo
19.3 c) A pastry chef
19.4 b) La recette d'Odette.
20.1 c) He walks now, slowly
20.2 c) See Odette again and see the sea
20.3 d) Two and a half hours
20.4 c) Et vous, madame Rose, qu'est-ce que vous aimeriez ?

Proverb index

- Episode 1 · « Chaque chose en son temps. » — Give each thing its own moment: finish your coffee before the next task.
- Episode 2 · « Il ne faut pas chercher midi à quatorze heures. » — Don't make a simple thing complicated.
- Episode 3 · « Petit à petit, l'oiseau fait son nid. » — Patience and small steps get big things done.
- Episode 4 · « Paris ne s'est pas fait en un jour. » — Great things take time and patience; you can't do them all at once.
- Episode 5 · « Qui ne dit mot consent. » — If you say nothing, people think you agree.
- Episode 6 · « C'est en forgeant qu'on devient forgeron. » — You learn by doing it again and again, mistakes included.
- Episode 7 · « Tout ce qui brille n'est pas or. » — Things that look wonderful aren't always what they seem.
- Episode 8 · « Il n'y a pas de sot métier. » — Every honest job deserves respect; none is beneath anyone.
- Episode 9 · « Mieux vaut tard que jamais. » — It's better to do something late than not at all.
- Episode 10 · « Il n'est pire sourd que celui qui ne veut pas entendre. » — The hardest person to reach is the one who won't listen.
- Episode 11 · « C'est dans les vieux pots qu'on fait les meilleures soupes. » — Experience and age are an advantage, not a weakness.
- Episode 12 · « Le mieux est l'ennemi du bien. » — Trying to make something perfect can spoil what was already good.
- Episode 13 · « La vérité sort de la bouche des enfants. » — Children often say simple true things that adults avoid.
- Episode 14 · « Qui ne tente rien n'a rien. » — If you never try, you never get anything.
- Episode 15 · « L'appétit vient en mangeant. » — Once you start doing something, the desire to do it grows.
- Episode 16 · « L'argent ne fait pas le bonheur. » — Being rich doesn't make you happy.
- Episode 17 · « Tel père, tel fils. » — Children often grow up like their parents.
- Episode 18 · « Rien ne sert de courir ; il faut partir à point. » — Rushing doesn't help; start calmly, at the right moment.
- Episode 19 · « Vouloir, c'est pouvoir. » — If you really want something, you find a way.
- Episode 20 · « Tout est bien qui finit bien. » — A happy ending makes the difficulties worth it.

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